

The Moral BRIGAND

The self-appointed commissar of Karnataka's moral brigade finds himself on the backfoot as liberal society promises just and instant retribution

By Swagata Sen

Pramod Mutalik is an angry man. There's a whole lot of people that he is angry with—pubbers, smokers, drinkers, porn filmmakers, cow slaughterers, “modern” women, Muslims, Christians, the BJP, L.K. Advani, the Shiv Sene, Bal Thackeray, greeting card companies, young lovers, rose sellers, so on and so forth. Left to him, he'd ban New Year's celebrations; Valentine's Day according to him is when young couples shouldn't hold hands and exchange gifts, but get married instead. He's so angry that he beats them up if they don't listen.

Mutalik, currently the poster boy of Karnataka's hardline Hindutva brigade, is also outrageous. So unbelievable are the comments and views of the Shri Ram Sene chief, whose members were behind the widely condemned attacks on women in a Mangalore pub two weeks ago and then on the daughter of a CPI(M) legislator, that you almost feel you haven't heard it right. Unapologetically, he says the beating was “for their own good”. Ask him why he feels he should appoint himself the moral guardian of Karnataka, and he touts his 33-year-old history of working for the sake of Hindutva in this country. A history which culminated within the last two weeks, because before that not many knew of his existence.

In cosmopolitan Bangalore, there are a lot of people who are angry too. Their irritation was so far measured, but now threatens to blow up into swift retaliation as the city's *aam janata* with the Pink Chaddi cam-



PRAMOD MUTALIK, THE SELF-PROCLAIMED MORAL GUARDIAN OF KARNATAKA